RAJASTHAN

# Raje's Show of Strength

By Rohit Parihar

On March 8, thousands of people attended a celebration at a temple in Rajasthan's Keshoraipatan, on the occasion of former chief minister Vasundhara Raje's 69th birthday. Ostensibly a personal affair, the huge gathering of fans and BJP workers was also a reminder, an assertion of the former CM's continuing political relevance.

Though Raje is a national vice president of the BJP, the party high command has sent few tasks her way since she lost the Rajasthan assembly election in December 2018. Her relations with the party's state unit are also frosty: state chief Satish Poonia and organisation secretary Chandrashekhar have largely been calling the shots, along with Rajendra Singh Rathore, deputy leader of the opposition and others from the anti-Raje camp. No one from Raje's camp has a major post in the state unit.

Raje herself has kept a low profile in recent years—that is, until November last year, when she made a string of public appearances at temples across five districts, gathering party workers and visiting the families of prominent leaders. The public response to her outreach has been noteworthy, but it has also stoked tensions with the state unit. In an alleged effort to prevent MLAs from attending Raje's birthday celebrations, it called a legislative meet on the day, but many MLAs chose to simply skip it. "Why is she challenging the state unit?" asks a BJP MP, asking to remain anonymous. "She does not need to. She is our leader, and we need her to come back to power." Some, like former parliamentary secretary Bhawani Singh Rajawat and former minister Rajpal Singh, have openly asked for Raje to be given charge.

**ON MARCH 8, MANY BJP LEGISLATORS SKIPPED A MEETING OF THE STATE UNIT TO ATTEND RAJE'S BIRTHDAY CELEBRATION**



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

**BIRTHDAY BASH**
Vasundhara Raje (right) at Keshoraipatan on March 8

Perhaps Raje is willing to ruffle feathers simply to remind the party high command of her importance in Rajasthan, where the next assembly election is just a year away. The BJP has few heavy hitters in the state. Though it has some big names—like Om Birla, speaker of the assembly, and Ashwini Vaishnaw, Gajendra Singh Shekhawat and Bhupendra Yadav, all cabinet ministers—none is a match for Raje when it comes to mobilising voters. Shekhawat is the only one to have demonstrated some ability to pull crowds, playing an instrumental role in making a Rajput rally under the Shri Kshatriya Yuvak Sangh banner in December a major success. What is also in Raje's favour is her proven skill at riding waves of anti-incumbency against the Gehlot government. In 2003, she led the party to a 120-seat haul in the 200-seat assembly, a record for the BJP. In 2013, she did it again, setting a new record with a 163-seat haul. And as CM, she has fared better than Gehlot when it comes to anti-incumbency—though the BJP lost the state assembly in 2018, the vote difference with the Congress was a meagre 150,000.

What should worry the BJP high command is its recent record at elections in the state. A series of elections in recent months showed the BJP unable to win seats or even secure respectable vote shares. In seven recent assembly bypolls in the state, the BJP was only able to win one seat. In urban local body polls, it is down about 10 per cent in seat count compared to its performance in 2014-15. In panchayat polls, it is down about 7.5 per cent. Experts say this just shows how badly the BJP needs Raje.

At her birthday celebration on March 8, her enduring magnetism was on full display. That she was able to electrify the audience, even drawing MLAs away from a state unit meeting, was ample proof that the former chief minister is eyeing a comeback. ■